Scrying Glass

DARK FANTASY MAGAZINE

Featuring stories by
Taryn Kloeden
Gregory Klyne
Clark Ashton Smith
Gareth Kloeden
...and more!

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A MESSAGE FROM THE MAGUS

Dearest reader - in your hands you hold the inaugural edition of a new publication of dark fantasy, sword and sorcery, and weird fiction. We've called it Scrying Glass because our goal is to take you out of the world of the mundane and give a glimpse of other planes that our authors have kindly decided to share.

In these pages you'll find tales of ancient skeletons, wizard marshalling forces beyond their control, heroes fighting battles they have no chance of winning, and more. We're proud to bring you five original tales, never before seen in print, plus one more from a legend of the pulps.

If writing is magic (and we believe it is), then the reader is the substrate upon which the spell is cast. So open your mind up, prepare to be dazzled, and start reading. We hope that you enjoy the stories here, and perhaps may even feel inspired to pick up a pen and work on your own magical practice. We'll be waiting for your submissions in subsequent issues.

With gratitude,

Gareth Kloeden

Magus-in-Chief, Scrying Glass

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The Secret of the Stars

Gareth Kloeden

The sorcerer Gwzak had not awoken on the Day of the Second Sun intending to invoke the most powerful spell in his vast arsenal of arcane knowledge. He peered out from the tallest window of his basalt tower at the city of Veilstar burning below. Acrid smoke accosted his senses. Faint cries and screams of pain reached him, perched high as he was at the top of the tallest tower that crowned the tallest of the hills.

Gwzak ran a gnarled hand through a shock of white hair. There were warnings that doom had been brewing for him and the rest of the mages that called the ancient city their home; warnings that went ignored. The chief of the antimagic demagogues, a brutal man who called himself Thrax, had toppled the city politic with lightning speed. Frenzied mobs were now fanning out across the city, taking their misguided vengeance on any magic user they could find.

In the merchant's quarter the vaulted doors of the lending houses were thrown open. Bankers whose magical aptitude extended little beyond practical cantrips to transport stacks of gold and jewels were dragged out, their fine silk shirts and velvet doublets torn open to reveal pale flesh into which their torturers carved obscene runes before stringing them up on makeshift gallows carted through the streets. For every new victim hanged a corpse was cut down and left to lay rotting in the stifling summer heat.

Gwzak saw this and similar scenes of carnage played out all across the city through numerous scrying mirrors. In their soundless surfaces he saw open mouths, claps and stomps, and he knew that the murderers sang as they worked. A sandy-haired youth whom Gwzak had bought champo from the month before joyously drew a razor across the throat of a white-robed monial. In anger Gwzak crushed a show globe in his hand, barely feeling the pain its glass shards cut into his palm as the crimson liquid within mixed with his blood.

Several of his colleagues had fled the city. Some had ridden out on winged reptilian beasts that they had hatched from an egg and raised like a child. Others retreated into microcosmic worlds that existed in collapsed dimensional spaces no bigger than the head of a pin, worlds they ruled as gods. A message lettered in the archaic script of sorcery was written across the open sky in green fire, informing those few who could read it that its author had simply chosen to end her existence.

Gwzak would not flee. He had once before, from a

different city in a different aeon, when the sky was a different color and he was known by a different name. He had allowed an ignorant mob of simpletons to dictate the course of his fate, and sworn never to repeat that mistake.

Only now, it was happening again. Here, in Veilstar, the cosmopolitan capital of the known world, where fortune could be won from rags and no man or woman was judged by their appearance or belief. Gwzak laughed at what a damnable lie that had been. All it had taken was a season of minor drought followed by disruption in the trade of exotic spices; the commonfolk of Veilstar, briefly deprived of their luxury goods and foodstuffs, had been prime clay for shaping into an instrument of violence.

He did not know why Thrax had chosen magic as the enemy. Perhaps the man was a failed wizard himself, or perhaps he was one of those many orphans created during the Sundering Wars three decades ago. Once, Gwzak would have tried to understand, even tried to mediate a peace. Now…

The sorcerer's ears perked up. He could hear it now, the singing. He looked up from a glass, where he had watched a bog witch-turned-herb-pedaler he frequented swallow gulps of saltpeter and brimstone, so that when a band of eight zealots broke down her door and rushed towards her, she detonated in a cloud of viscous green that left nothing recognizable as human in its wake.

He tugged creases from the ultramarine sleeves of the voluminous vicuña robe he wore. When the mob inevitably came to his doorstep they would find their

crude, ignorant malice opposed by a man of learning and sophistication. Gwzak had spent centuries probing the depths of reality and parlaying what he found there to rise high in this existence. In a dusty corner of his mind palace lay a memory of thirteen years spent in the singular study of a gossamer scroll written by an extinct race that had inhabited the surface of a cold brown star. He was not like these vulgarians. He was under no illusion that he would change their minds or stop their frenzy. It was far too late for that.

Out of his window he could now see his nearest neighbor fall victim. Mithrop was known across the city as one who spent his dotage entertaining children's parties with displays of multicolored rockets. Fire licked at his squat tower, blackening the alabaster. Loud bangs accompanied starbursts of crimson, chartreuse, and indigo. A few moments later a huge man exited the tower, and Gwzak looked on as Thrax the demagogue, followed by a parade of followers, strolled towards the basalt walls of his own tower, all of them chanting the same bloodthirsty song.

Thrax's fist sent reverberations through the tower's snakewood door. After a moment he shrugged, and gestured to sycophants who threw flaming brands at the base of the tower.

A wicket door opened and an iridescent salamander with a body of glass poked its elongated head out. In Gwzak's voice it spoke to the mob assaulting his tower.

"Cease this pathetic clamour," said the salamander.

"Such sorcery that makes beasts speak must be punished further!" said Thrax.

"You, Thrax, are doomed. I give the rest of you ruffians one chance. Turn back now. Lay down your arms and surrender."

"A demon's tongue! Do not listen to these lies; he seeks to turn us against each other. Treachery is inherent in the wizard. They know little else."

Gwzak hoped for even the slightest hesitation, a glimmer of doubt amongst a single follower. Through the opal eyes of the salamander he saw none. His warnings only further inflamed the rage of the attackers.

"Very well. Let it be recorded that Gwzak of Ilmynÿo offered quarter to the rabble of Veilstar and was refused. In exchange they will learn of true violence."

The salamander slid back, the wicket closing just as a stone collided with it. Gwzak pulled a lever and listened satisfied to a series of whirs and clicks as his numerous glasses positioned themselves in a circle around him. Their surfaces silvered and revealed infinite Gwzaks; he closed his eyes, placed his palms down. The battering of fist and stone faded until it was no more than a distant echo. The sorcerer invoked the Seventh Sight of the Overworld and now saw his meditative body from above, and in each of the mirrors no longer a reflection but a different wing of the vast castle of memory that had been constructed neuron by neuron over centuries. There, in the ninety-secondth glass, was what he sought. An

unassuming storeroom, littered with rusted tools and dirty alchemical implements.

He found the heavy metal box, half-concealed beneath a moth-eaten curtain. Such were the contents of this box that he had locked it with a key fashioned from his own lifeblood, and now he drew open an astral vein and let thirteen subjective years of his life flow out into the lock.

Inside was a rolled yellowed parchment. The mental avatar of Gwzak lifted the scroll, committed to memory so long ago. It bore a tripartite symbol stamped into its wax seal.

Here, learned from that dead race of galactic antiquity, was the secret of the stars. He broke the seal. The storeroom vanished; Gwzak opened his eyes. He willed the snakewood to wither; Thrax and his band, thinking they had breached the door, stormed up the twisted stairs that led to the chamber of mirrors.

Gwzak's lips moved and as they did he was overtaken by a feeling of great wrongness. He found that he did not truly care; this city, this iteration of the world, had made its own decisions and brought about its own fate. That he was to be the deliverer of its judgment was ancillary, a cosmic coincidence.

The tower began to shake violently. Its basalt shell fell off in pieces, crushing numerous ruffians below and the few surviving civilians they held in captivity. Gwzak's seat in the center of the chamber began to

descend, spiraling downwards through the length of the tower. He watched as his assaulters fell from the stairs, bones and heads cracking on the concrete far below.

When he had come down near to the base of the tower he met the eyes of Thrax, red and wild with fury. Gwzak found that he had nothing to say to the man. He shook his head, and continued his descent into the buried superstructure that was the underground counterpart of what had been his tower.

Gwzak sat in darkness, waiting. He did not have to wait long.

Earth had not seen destruction of the kind that wiped the city of Veilstar and all of its inhabitants from the planet's face in many aeons. Those of neighboring cities who escaped the destruction later spoke of a second sun shining and a great cloud of ash that obscured the horizon for days.

Deep underground, Gwzak willed a series of lights to life. The effort had tired him; he shuffled to a cylindrical installation, large enough to hold a single man. He manipulated the panel at its front then climbed in. He enjoyed the blast of frigid air that came before the blackness.

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The sorcerer Gwzak emerged from his long hibernation to find a scene of marvels. Conical towers of a familiar color dotted the landscape; in the dark blue sky

flew steady streams of figures glinting metallic. Above all sat a dim red sun backstopped by a carpet of twinkling stars.

A winged woman with enormous yellow eyes buzzed down, curious at the sight of the wingless gray-haired creature surfacing from a hillside.

Gwzak looked at her. He smiled, and she smiled back with gleaming sharpened teeth.

The Ninth Skeleton

Clark Ashton Smith

It was beneath the immaculate blue of a morning in April that I set out to keep my appointment with Guenevere. We had agreed to meet on Boulder Ridge, at a spot well known to both of us, a small and circular field surrounded with pines and full of large stones, midway between her parents' home at Newcastle and my cabin on the north-eastern extremity of the Ridge, near Auburn.

Guenevere is my fiancée. It must be explained that at the time of which I write, there was a certain amount of opposition on the part of her parents to the engagement — an opposition since happily withdrawn. In fact, they had gone so far as to forbid me to call, and Guenevere and I could see each other only by stealth, and infrequently,

The Ridge is a long and rambling moraine, heavily strewn in places with boulders, as its name implies, and

with many outcroppings of black volcanic stone. Fruit-ranches cling to some of its slopes, but scarcely any of the top is under cultivation, and much of the soil, indeed, is too thin and stony. to be arable. With its twisted pines, often as fantastic in form as the cypresses of the California coast, and its gnarled and stunted oaks, the landscape has a wild and quaint beauty, with more than a hint of the Japanesque in places.

It is perhaps two miles from my cabin to the place where I was to meet Guenevere. Since I was born in the very shadow of Boulder Ridge, and have lived upon or near it for most of my thirty-odd years, I am familiar with every rod of its lovely and rugged extent, and, previous to that April morning, would scarcely have refrained from laughing if anyone had told me I could possibly lose my way... Since then — well, I assure you, I should not feel inclined to laugh...

Truly, it was a morning made for the trysts of lovers. Wild bees were humming busily in the patches of clover and in the ceanothus bushes with their great masses of white flowers, whose strange and heavy perfume intoxicated the air. Most of the spring blossoms were abroad: cyclamen, yellow violet, poppy, wild hyacinth, and woodland star; and the green of the fields was opalescent with their colouring. Between the emerald of the buck- eyes, the grey-green of the pines, the golden and dark and bluish greens of the oaks, I caught glimpses of the snow-white Sierras to the east, and the faint blue of the Coast Range to the west, beyond the pale and lilac levels of the Sacramento valley. Following a vague trail, I went onwards across open fields where I had to thread

my way among clustering boulders.

My thoughts were all of Guenevere, and I looked only with a casual and desultory eye at the picturesqueness and vernal beauty that environed my path. I was half-way between my cabin and the meeting-place, when I became suddenly aware that the sunlight had darkened, and glanced up, thinking, of course, that an April cloud, appearing unobserved from beyond the horizon, had passed across the sun. Imagine, then, my surprise when I saw that the azure of the entire sky had turned to a dun and sinister brown, in the midst of which the sun was clearly visible, burning like an enormous round red ember. Then, something strange and unfamiliar in the nature of my surroundings, which I was momentarily at a loss to define, forced itself upon my attention, and my surprise became a growing consternation. I stopped and looked about me, and realized, incredible as it seemed, that I had lost my way; for the pines on either hand were not those that I had expected to see. They were more gigantic, more gnarled, than the ones I remembered; and their roots writhed in wilder end more serpentine contortions from a soil that was strangely lowerless, and where even the grass grew only in scanty tufts. There were boulders large as druidic monoliths, and the forms of some of them were such as one might see in a nightmare, Thinking, of course, that it must all be a dream, but with a sense of utter bewilderment which seldom if ever attends the absurdities and monstrosities of nightmare, I sought in vain to orient myself and to find some familiar landmark in the bizarre scene that lay before me.

A path, broader than the one I had been following, but running in what I judged to be the same direction, wound on among the trees. It was covered with a grey dust, which, as I went forward, became deeper and displayed footprints of a singular form — footprints that were surely too attenuate, too fantastically slender, to be human, despite their five toe-marks. Something about them, I know not what, something in the nature of their very thinness and elongation, made me shiver. Afterwards, I wondered why I had not recognized them for what they were; but at the time, no suspicion entered my mind — only a vague sense of disquietude, au indefinable trepidation.

As I proceeded, the pines amid which I passed became momentarily more fantastic and more sinister in the contortions of their boughs and boles and roots. Some were like leering hags; others were obscenely crouching gargoyles; some appeared to writhe in an eternity of hellish torture; others were convulsed as with a satanic merrirnent. All the while, the sky continued to darken slowly, the dun and dismal brown that I had first perceived turning through almost imperceptible changes of tone to a dead funereal purple, wherein the sun smouldered like a moon that had risen from a bath of blood. The trees and the whole landscape were saturated with this macabre purple, were immersed and steeped in its unnatural gloom. Only the rocks, as I went on, grew strangely paler; and their forms were somehow suggestive of headstones, of tombs and monuments. Beside the trail, there was no longer the green of vernal grass — only an earth mottled by drying algae and tiny

lichens the colour of verdigris. Also there were patches of evil-looking fungi with stems of a leprous pallor and blackish heads that drooped and nodded loathsomely.

The sky had now grown so dark that the whole scene took on a semi-nocturnal aspect, and made me think of a doomed world in the twilight of a dying sun. All was airless and silent; there were no birds, no insects, no sighing of the pines, no lisping of leaves: a baleful and preternatural silence, like the silence of the infinite void.

The trees became denser, then dwindled, and I came to a circular field, Here, there was no mistaking the nature of the monolithal boulders — they were headstones and funeral monuments, but so enormously ancient that the letterings or figures upon them were well-nigh effaced; and the few characters that I could distinguish were not of any known language. About them there the hoariness and mystery and terror of incomputable Eld. It was hard to believe that life and death could be as old as they. The trees around them were inconceivably gnarled and bowed as with an almost equal burden of years. The sense of awful antiquity that these stones and pines all served to convey increased the oppression of my bewilderment, confirmed my disquietude. Nor was I reassured when I noticed on the soft earth about the headstones a number of those attenuate footprints of which I have already spoken. They were disposed in a fashion that was truly singular seeming to depart from and return to the vicinity of each stone.

Now, for the first time, I heard a sound other than

the sound of my own footfalls in the silence of this macabre scene. Behind me, among the trees, there was a faint and evil rattling. I turned and listened; there was something in these sounds that served to complete the demoralization of my unstrung nerves; and monstrous fears, abominable fancies, trooped like the horde of a witches' sabbat through my brain.

The reality that I was now to confront was no less monstrous! There was a whitish glimmering in the shadow of the trees, and a human skeleton, bearing in its arms the skeleton of an infant, emerged and came towards me! Intent as on some ulterior cryptic purpose, some charnel errand not to be surmised by the living, it went by with a tranquil pace, an effortless and gliding tread in which, despite my terror and stupefaction, I perceived a certain horrible and feminine grace. I followed the apparition with my eyes as it passed among the monuments without pausing and vanished in the darkness of the pines on the opposite side of the field. No sooner had it gone, than a second, also bearing in its arms an infant skeleton, appeared, and passed before me in the same direction and with the same abominable and loathsome grace of movement.

A horror that was more than horror, a fear that was beyond fear, petrified all my faculties, and I felt as if I were weighted down by some ineluctable and insupportable burden of nightmare, Before me, skeleton after skeleton, each precisely like the last, with the same macabre lightness and ease of motion, each carrying its pitiful infant, emerged from the shadow of the ancient pines and followed where the first had disappeared, intent

as on the same cryptic errand. One by one they came, till I had counted eight! Now I knew the origin of the bizarre footprints whose attenuation had disturbed and troubled me.

When the eighth skeleton had passed from sight, my eyes were drawn as by scene irresistible impulsion to one of the nearer headstones, beside which I was amazed to perceive what I had not noticed before: a freshly opened grave, gaping darkly in the soft soil. Then, at my elbow, I heard a low rattling, and the fingers of a fleshless hand plucked lightly at my sleeve. A skeleton was beside me, differing only from the others through the fact that it bore no infant in its arms. With a lipless and iagratiating leer, it plucked again at my sleeve, as if to draw me towards the open grave, and its teeth clicked as if it were trying to speak. My senses and my brain, aswirl with vertiginous terror, could endure no more: I seemed to fall and fall through deeps of infinite eddying blackness with the clutching terror of those fingers upon my arm, till consciousness was left behind in my descent.

When I came to, Guenevere was holding me by the arm, concern and puzzlement upon her sweet oval face, and I was standing among the boulders of the field appointed for our rendezvous.

'What on earth is the matter with you, Herbert?' she queried anxiously. 'Are you ill? You were standing here in a daze when I came, and didn't seem to hear or see me when I spoke to you. And I really thought you were going to faint when I touched your arm.'